FREE SAMPLE · CHAPTERS 1-3

THE REPTILE RESET

Leopard gecko and bearded dragon care, done right from day one.



About This Sample

This is a free extract from **The Reptile Reset**, a step-by-step care system for leopard geckos and bearded dragons.

The three chapters here explain why pet reptiles get sick, how to choose between a leopard gecko and a bearded dragon, and how to get temperatures right. Get those three right, and most health problems never start.

CHAPTER 1

Why Reptiles Get Sick in Captivity

A reptile depends on its environment far more than a dog or a cat does. It can't make its own body heat, and it relies on the right light and diet to build strong bones. Get the environment wrong, and the reptile slowly gets sick, even if it eats and looks fine for months.

Reptiles are masters of hiding illness

In the wild, a reptile that looks weak gets eaten. So reptiles have evolved to hide illness for as long as they possibly can. By the time a pet reptile *looks* sick, the problem has usually been building for weeks or months.

That's why this guide focuses on getting the set-up right and spotting small changes early, rather than waiting for obvious symptoms.

The real reasons pet reptiles get sick

1. The wrong temperatures. Reptiles digest food, fight infection and move using heat from their surroundings. Too cold, and digestion and immunity slow down. Too hot, with nowhere cooler to go, and they overheat. (Chapter 3)

2. No UVB, or the wrong UVB. Leopard geckos and bearded dragons use ultraviolet B light to make vitamin D3, which they need to absorb calcium. Without it, their bones weaken. (Chapter 4)

3. A poor diet and missing supplements. Feeder insects alone aren't a complete diet. Without calcium and vitamin supplements, deficiencies build up. (Chapter 6)

4. An enclosure that's too small or badly set up. There's no room for a proper heat gradient, too few hides, and constant stress. (Chapter 5)

5. Guesswork instead of measuring. Stick-on dial thermometers, heat mats without thermostats, and "a bulb that looks bright enough" are behind a huge number of problems. (Chapters 3 and 4)

6. Housing reptiles together. Both leopard geckos and bearded dragons are best kept alone. Pairs and groups often fight, stress each other, or compete for heat and food. (Chapter 2)

"But the pet shop said..."

A lot of common reptile advice is out of date. Reptile care has improved enormously in the last two decades, but old habits survive in starter kits and forums.

Outdated advice	Current understanding
A small starter tank is fine for life	Adults need far more space (Chapter 5)
Leopard geckos don't need UVB	Low-level UVB is now widely recommended (Chapter 4)
Heat rocks are a good heat source	They cause serious burns. Never use them
Coloured night bulbs let you watch them at night	Light at night disrupts sleep. Use darkness, plus a heat source that gives no light if needed
Calcium sand is safe because it's digestible	Not recommended. Choose a safer substrate (Chapter 5)
Two reptiles keep each other company	Both species are best housed alone

Measure, don't guess

For most reptile keepers, the biggest single upgrade is **measuring instead of guessing**:

- digital probe thermometers
- an infrared temperature gun for surfaces
- a thermostat on every heat source
- a kitchen scale to track weight

Each of these costs less than a vet visit. Together, they prevent most problems before they start.

> **The rule for this whole guide:** when something looks wrong, check the temperatures and the lighting before anything else.

CHAPTER 2

Leopard Gecko or Bearded Dragon?

Both make excellent beginner reptiles, but they suit different homes and different people. Choose based on your space, your schedule and how you want to interact with your pet, not on which one looks cuter in the shop.

Side by side

	Leopard gecko	Bearded dragon
Adult size	About 18–25 cm (7–10 in)	About 45–60 cm (18–24 in)
Lifespan	Commonly 15–20 years	Commonly 10–15 years
Active	Mainly dawn, dusk and night	Daytime
Minimum adult enclosure	About 90×45×45 cm (36×18×18 in). Bigger is better	About 120×60×60 cm (48×24×24 in). Bigger is better
Diet	Insects only	Insects and plants. Adults eat mostly plants
UVB	Low-level UVB recommended	Strong UVB essential
Basking surface temperature	About 32–35°C (90–95°F)	About 40–43°C (104–110°F)
Handling	Usually tolerates gentle handling once settled	Often calm and very tolerant with regular handling
Set-up cost	Lower	Higher: bigger enclosure, stronger lighting, more electricity
Daily time	Low	Moderate: fresh greens every day, more cleaning

Which one suits you?

A leopard gecko might suit you if you have limited space, you're out during the day, you'd rather not prepare fresh vegetables, and you're ready for a pet that may live 20 years.

A bearded dragon might suit you if you want an active daytime pet that's awake when you are, you have room for a large enclosure, and you're happy to prepare a salad most days.

One reptile per enclosure

Keep one reptile per enclosure. After temperature and lighting, housing reptiles together is the most common beginner mistake.

- **Bearded dragons** housed together often fight, bite off toes and tail tips, and compete for the basking spot. The smaller one can stay stressed and underfed, even without obvious fighting.
- **Male leopard geckos** fight. Females are sometimes kept together, but it still risks stress and competition, and it's not recommended for beginners.
- **Never mix species** in one enclosure.

Reptiles don't get lonely the way social mammals do. A single reptile in a good set-up isn't missing out.

Where to get one

- **A reputable breeder** is usually the best choice. Good breeders know the animal's age and history, feed it properly, and answer your questions after you buy.
- **A reptile rescue** is a great option. Many leopard geckos and bearded dragons are given up by owners who weren't prepared.
- **Pet shops vary enormously.** Some are excellent; others keep reptiles in poor conditions. Judge a shop by how its animals live.

Choosing a healthy reptile

Look for:

- **Alertness:** eyes open and bright, reacting to movement
- **Good body condition:** a leopard gecko's tail should be reasonably plump, not thinner than its neck. A bearded dragon shouldn't have visible hip bones or a sunken base of the tail
- **A clean vent** (the opening under the base of the tail), with no crusting or staining
- **Straight limbs, a firm jaw and a straight spine**
- **No stuck shed** on the toes or tail tip
- **Clear breathing:** no wheezing, bubbles or mucus around the nose or mouth
- **A good appetite:** ask to see it eat, or ask when it last ate

Avoid:

- very young, tiny animals that are still fragile
- lethargic animals with closed or sunken eyes
- very thin animals
- animals kept in dirty or crowded enclosures

- sellers who can't tell you what the animal eats, or what temperatures they keep it at

Ask the seller for: the reptile's approximate age, what it eats and how often, its sex if known, and any health history.

CHAPTER 3

Temperature and the Thermal Gradient

Why heat matters so much

Reptiles are **ectotherms**: they can't make enough body heat themselves, so they use their surroundings to warm up and cool down. How fast they digest food, fight infection, grow and move depends on their body temperature.

- **Too cold:** a reptile can't digest properly. Food can sit and rot in its gut, it becomes sluggish, and its immune system slows down.
- **Too hot, with no cooler area to retreat to:** it can overheat and die.

The thermal gradient

The answer isn't one "right" temperature. It's a **gradient**: a warm end and a cool end, so the reptile can move between them and choose the temperature it needs at any moment.

- **The basking spot:** the hottest area, directly under the heat source.
- **The warm side:** warm, but less intense than the basking spot.
- **The cool side:** noticeably cooler, where the reptile can cool down.
- **Night:** temperatures can drop. A natural night-time drop is healthy for both species.

Without enough space for a real gradient, the whole enclosure ends up either too hot or too cool. That's one of the main reasons small enclosures cause problems.

Target temperatures

Zone	Leopard gecko	Bearded dragon
Basking surface	32–35°C (90–95°F)	40–43°C (104–110°F). Juveniles toward the higher end
Warm side	28–32°C (82–90°F)	30–35°C (86–95°F)
Cool side	22–26°C (72–79°F)	24–29°C (75–84°F)
Night	Can drop to about 18–21°C (65–70°F)	Can drop to about 18–21°C (65–70°F)

These are typical ranges. Your reptile's behaviour (Chapter 9) tells you whether it's comfortable.

How to measure properly

Surface temperature and air temperature are different. A basking reptile absorbs heat from the surface it lies on and from the heat source above it. The air a few centimetres away can be much cooler.

You need two tools:

1. **A digital thermometer with a probe,** ideally two, one on each side. Place the probes at the level your reptile actually sits, not at the top of the enclosure. They measure the air temperature on the warm and cool sides.
2. **An infrared temperature gun.** Point it at the basking surface to read the temperature where your reptile lies.

Don't rely on stick-on dial thermometers. They're often off by several degrees, and they measure the glass rather than the conditions your reptile experiences.

Check temperatures at different times of day for the first few weeks: morning, afternoon and evening. Record them in the **Temperature Log (Appendix A)**. Room temperature changes with the seasons, so check again when the weather turns.

Heat sources

Heat source	Good for	Notes
Halogen flood bulb	Basking spot, both species	Gives heat and light, much like sunlight. The most natural choice for a basking spot. Use a dimming thermostat
Deep heat projector or ceramic heat emitter	Background heat, or heat at night	Heats without light, so it doesn't disturb sleep. Always use a thermostat
Heat mat	Warm-side floor heat for leopard geckos	Must be on a thermostat. Place it under part of the enclosure, never the whole floor
Heat rock	Nothing	Never use. A known cause of severe burns
Coloured "night" bulbs (red, blue, purple)	Nothing	Light at night disturbs sleep. Use darkness, plus a heat source that gives no light if the room gets too cold

Thermostats are not optional

Every heat source must be connected to a thermostat. A thermostat measures the temperature with its own probe and switches or dims the heater to hold the level you set.

- **Dimming thermostats** suit bulbs.
- **On/off thermostats** suit heat mats and ceramic heaters, but not bulbs, which wear out quickly when switched on and off over and over.
- **Place the thermostat probe** in the area that heater warms, and secure it so your reptile can't move it. A dislodged probe can make the heater run non-stop.
- **Check the thermostat against your separate thermometer.** Thermostats can fail.

Seasons and room changes

The room affects your reptile's enclosure. A cold winter room can pull the whole gradient down, and a hot summer room can push the cool side too high.

- **In winter:** check the cool side and night temperatures. If the night drops too low, add a heat source that gives no light, on a thermostat.
- **In summer:** check the cool side isn't getting too warm. Keep the enclosure out of direct sunlight, which can overheat a glass enclosure within minutes.

What's In The Full Guide

This sample covered the first three chapters. The complete guide continues with:

- **Lighting and UVB**: the right type, strength and distance for each species, and when to replace it
- **Building the enclosure**: sizes, substrate, hides, humidity and a set-up checklist
- **Feeding and supplements**: insects, the bearded dragon salad list, and dusting schedules
- **Bringing your reptile home** and **the care routine**
- **The diagnostic**: what behaviour, body changes and droppings actually mean
- **Common health problems**: MBD, impaction, respiratory infection, parasites, egg-binding and more
- **Emergency first aid** before you reach the vet
- **Shedding without stress** and **handling and taming**
- **Full species profiles** for the leopard gecko and the bearded dragon, including body language
- **Brumation, holidays and power cuts**
- **The ten most common mistakes**
- **A 30-day reptile reset plan**

Printable extras: temperature log, feeding and weight log, diagnostic cheat sheet, and set-up and bulb tracker.